

The Hipparchus

ΙΠΠΑΡΧΟΣ

Plato

translated by Thomas Taylor (1804)

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The Hipparchus

225a

Socrates: What is the love, and who are the lovers of gain?

225a

Hipparchus: It appears to me that those are lovers of gain, who think it worth while to acquire wealth from things of no worth.

225a

Socrates: Whether therefore do they appear to you to do this in consequence of knowing, or being ignorant that these are things of no worth? For if they do this through ignorance, you call the lovers of gain stupid.

225a

Hipparchus: But I do not call them stupid, but perfectly crafty and base; men who are vanquished by gain, who know that the things from which they have the boldness to acquire wealth, are of no worth, and yet at the same time, through their impudence, dare to love gain.

225b

Socrates: Do you, therefore, call a character of the following kind a lover of gain? I mean, as if a husbandman, planting a tree or herb, and knowing that it is of no worth, should nevertheless think it worth while to enrich himself from the cultivation of such a plant? Do you call such a one as this a lover of gain?

225b

Hipparchus: A lover of gain, Socrates, thinks he ought to enrich himself from every thing.

225b

Socrates: Do not thus rashly answer me, like a man who has been injured by some one; but, attending to what I say, answer me as if I should again interrogate you from the beginning. Do you agree with me, that a lover of gain knows the value of that thing whence he thinks it worth while to enrich himself?

225b

Hipparchus: I do.

225b

Socrates: Who then is he that has a knowledge of the worth of plants; and who likewise knows in what region, and at what time of the year it is worth while to plant them? that we also may adopt something from those words of the wise, which lawyers employ for the sake of elegance.

225c

Hipparchus: A husbandman, I think.

225c

Socrates: Do you, therefore, say that the term, It is worth while to acquire wealth, is any thing else than to think that it is requisite to acquire wealth?

225d

Hipparchus: I say it is this very thing.

225d

Socrates: Do not therefore you, who are so young, endeavour to deceive me, who am now an elderly man, by answering, as you do at present, what you by no means think; but answer me truly, whether you think that the man who is a husbandman, and who knows that it is not worth while to set a certain plant, will yet expect to be enriched by such a plant?

225e

Hipparchus: By Jupiter, not I.

226a

Socrates: What then? Will a jockey who knows that the food which he gives a horse is of no worth, be ignorant that by such food he will destroy the horse?

226a

Hipparchus: I do not think he will.

226b

Socrates: He will not, therefore, think that from such alimant as this, which is of no worth, he shall be enriched.

226b

Hipparchus: He will not.

226b

Socrates: What then? Do you think that a pilot who furnishes a ship with a rudder and sails, which are of no value, can be ignorant that he shall sustain an injury, be himself in danger of perishing, and both destroy the ship and all it contains?

226b

Hipparchus: I do not.

226b

Socrates: He will not therefore think that he shall be enriched by furniture of no value.

226b

Hipparchus: He will not.

226b

Socrates: Will the general of an army, likewise, when he knows that his soldiers have arms which are of no value, think that he shall acquire wealth, or that it is worth while to be enriched by these?

226b

Hipparchus: By no means.

226b

Socrates: In like manner, if a piper possesses a pipe of no value, a lyrist a lyre, an archer a bow, or in short

226c

if any other artist or skilful person possesses instruments, or any other apparatus of no value, will he think that he shall be enriched by these?

226d

Hipparchus: It appears he will not.

226d

Socrates: Who then do you call lovers of gain? For they are certainly not those whom we have already mentioned, who expect to be enriched from things which they know are of no value. And thus, O wonderful man, according to what you say, no one is a lover of gain.

226e

Hipparchus: But I, Socrates, wish to say, that those are lovers of gain, who, through insatiable avidity, transcendently aspire after things very small and trifling, and which are of no value, and this for the sake of gain.

226e

Socrates: But certainly, O best of men, they do not act in this manner, knowing that they are things of no worth; for we have granted that this is impossible.

226e

Hipparchus: So it appears to me.

226e

Socrates: If, therefore, they do not act in this manner knowingly, it is evident that their conduct must be the effect of ignorance; the consequence of thinking that things which are of no worth are highly valuable.

226e

Hipparchus: It appears so.

226e

Socrates: Do the lovers of gain, love any thing else than gain?

226e

Hipparchus: Nothing else.

226e

Socrates: But do you say that gain is contrary to loss?

227a

Hipparchus: I do.

227a

Socrates: Is it therefore good to any one to suffer a loss?

227a

Hipparchus: To no one.

227a

Socrates: Is it then an evil?

227a

Hipparchus: Yes.

227a

Socrates: Are men, therefore, injured by loss?

227a

Hipparchus: They are injured.

227a

Socrates: Is then loss an evil?

227a

Hipparchus: It is.

227a

Socrates: And is gain contrary to loss?

227a

Hipparchus: Contrary.

227a

Socrates: Is gain therefore good?

227a

Hipparchus: It is.

227b

Socrates: Do you, therefore, call those that love good, lovers of gain?

227b

Hipparchus: So it seems.

227b

Socrates: You do not then, my friend, call the lovers of gain insane persons. But with respect to yourself, whether do you love that which is good, or do not love it?

227b

Hipparchus: I love it.

227b

Socrates: Is there a certain good which you do not love, but a certain evil which you do?

227b

Hipparchus: By Jupiter, there is not.

227b

Socrates: But you love all good things equally.

227b

Hipparchus: I do.

227b

Socrates: Ask me, if I also do not. For I also shall acknowledge to you, that I love things good. But besides I and you, do not all other men appear to you to love things good, and hate such as are evil?

227b

Hipparchus: To me it appears so.

227b

Socrates: But have we not acknowledged that gain is good?

227b

Hipparchus: Yes.

227b

Socrates: After this manner, therefore, all lovers of gain appear; but according to that mode which we before mentioned, no one was a lover of gain. By employing which of these two, then, shall we not err?

227b

Hipparchus: If any one, Socrates, rightly apprehends what a lover of gain is, I think he will rightly consider him to be a character of this kind, who earnestly applies himself to the acquisition of wealth, and thinks it worth while to enrich himself from those things from which good men never dare to enrich themselves.

227c

Socrates: But do you not see, O sweetest of men, that we just now acknowledged that to be enriched is to be benefited?

227d

Hipparchus: But what then?

227d

Socrates: Because this also we previously admitted, that all men always aspired after things good.

227d

Hipparchus: We did.

227d

Socrates: Will not, therefore, good men wish to possess every thing lucrative, since every thing lucrative is good?

227d

Hipparchus: But they will not, Socrates, desire things lucrative, by which they may be injured.

227e

Socrates: Do you say that to be injured, is to suffer a loss, or that it is something else?

227e

Hipparchus: I say it is no other than to suffer a loss.

227e

Socrates: Do men, therefore, suffer a loss through gain, or through loss?

227e

Hipparchus: Through both. For they suffer a loss through loss, and through base gain.

227e

Socrates: Does it therefore appear to you that any thing useful and good is base?

227e

Hipparchus: It does not.

227e

Socrates: Did we not then, a little before this, acknowledge that gain is contrary to loss, which is an evil?

228a

Hipparchus: We did.

228a

Socrates: And that being contrary to evil, it is good?

228a

Hipparchus: We granted this.

228a

Socrates: You see therefore that you endeavour to deceive me, and that you designedly assert the contrary to that which we just now granted.

228a

Hipparchus: I do not, by Jupiter, Socrates: but, on the contrary, you deceive me; and I do not know how it is, but in your discourse you turn all things upwards and downwards.

228a

Socrates: Good words, I beseech you. For indeed I should not act well, if I were not persuaded by a good and wise man.

228b

Hipparchus: Who is he? and to what purpose is this?

228b

Socrates: My fellow citizen, and likewise yours, Hipparchus the son of the Philædonic Pisistratus, and the eldest and wisest of the sons of Pisistratus. This man, besides exhibiting many other illustrious works of wisdom, was the first that introduced into this land the writings of Homer, and compelled the rhapsodists to recite them in the Panathenaia, alternately, and in order, just as you know they do at present. He likewise brought back Anacreon, who was sent to Teium, in a ship of fifty oars:

228c

and always had about him Simonides of Chius; persuading him to reside with him, by great rewards and gifts. He did these things, wishing to persuade his citizens, that thus he might rule over the best of men; thinking, that it was not proper to envy any man the

possession of wisdom, and this because he himself was a worthy and good man. As, therefore, his fellow citizens were well educated men, and admired him for his wisdom, he likewise endeavoured to instruct the husbandmen, and in order to this, placed Hermæ for them in the roads, in the middle of the city, and in each of the towns.

228d

Afterwards, from this wisdom of his, which he partly learned, and partly himself discovered, selecting such things as he thought were the wisest, he inserted them in an elegy, and inscribed this work, HIS POEMS, and SPECIMENS OF WISDOM. This he did, in the first place, that his citizens might not admire those wise inscriptions in the temple of Delphi, “Know thyself,” “Nothing too much,” and the rest of this kind, but that they might think the words of Hipparchus were to be preferred for wisdom to these:

228e

and, in the next place, that by every where reading and receiving a taste of his wisdom, they might come from the fields, and be instructed in the other branches of learning. But there are two epigrams, one on the left hand part of each of the Hermæ, in which, according to the inscription, Hermes says, that the column should stand in the middle of the city, and the people; and the other on the right hand part; which was thus inscribed:

229a

“This monument was raised by Hipparchus—Persist in paying attention to justice.” There are also many other beautiful inscriptions, on other Hermæ; and the following is to be seen in the Stiriatic road: “This monument was raised by Hipparchus—Do not deceive your friend.” I therefore, being your friend, dare not deceive you, and oppose the mandate of so great a man; after whose death, the Athenians were under tyrannic subjection to his brother Hippias.

229b

And you must have heard from all old men, that there never was a tyranny in Athens till these three years past, and that during every

other time, the Athenians lived somewhat nearly after the same manner, as when Saturn reigned. But it is said by more elegant men, that he did not die in the way which the multitude report, viz. through the ignominy of his sister Canephoria; (for it is absurd to suppose that this was the case;) but that Harmodius was beloved and instructed by Aristogiton, who valued himself very highly on this account, and thought that Hipparchus would be his antagonist.

229c

But at that time it happened that Harmodius was the lover of a certain noble and beautiful youth, whose name I have heard, but do not at present remember. This young man then at first admired Harmodius and Aristogiton, as wise men, but afterwards associating with Hipparchus, he despised them; and they being very much afflicted with the disgrace, slew Hipparchus.

229d

Hipparchus: You appear, therefore, Socrates, either not to consider me as a friend; or; if you do think me a friend, not to be persuaded by Hipparchus: for I do not know how to persuade myself that you have not deceived me in the preceding discourse.

229d

Socrates: But indeed, just as in the game of chess, I am willing to retract whatever you please, that you may not think I have deceived you. Whether therefore shall I retract this assertion for you, that all men desire good?

229e

Hipparchus: Not for me.

229e

Socrates: Shall I retract this then, that neither to sustain a loss, nor a loss itself, is an evil?

229e

Hipparchus: Not for me.

229e

Socrates: Shall it be this then, that gain, and to acquire gain, are contrary to loss, and to suffer a loss?

230a

Hipparchus: Nor this neither.

230a

Socrates: Shall I retract this assertion, that to acquire gain, as being contrary to evil, is good?

230a

Hipparchus: You shall not retract any thing of this.

230a

Socrates: It appears to you, therefore, as it seems, that of gain one part is good, and another part evil.

230a

Hipparchus: To me it does appear so.

230a

Socrates: I will therefore retract this for you. For let it be that one kind of gain is good, and another kind evil: but gain itself is not more good than evil. For is it?

230a

Hipparchus: Why do you ask me?

230a

Socrates: I will tell you. Is there good, and is there likewise bad, food?

230b

Hipparchus: Yes.

230b

Socrates: Is therefore one of them more food than the other? or are both of them similarly food? and does the one in no respect differ from the other, so far as each is food, but so far as one is good, and the other bad?

230b

Hipparchus: Yes.

230b

Socrates: And does it not likewise follow with respect to drink, and all other things which participate of the good and the bad, that they differ in no respect from each other, in that in which they are the same? Just as with respect to our own species, one man is good, and another bad.

230b

Hipparchus: Yes.

230b

Socrates: But with respect to men, I think that one man is neither more nor less a man than another, neither the good than the bad, nor the bad than the good.

230b

Hipparchus: True.

230b

Socrates: Must we not therefore think in the same manner respecting gain, that both the good and the bad are similarly gain?

230b

Hipparchus: It is necessary.

230b

Socrates: He, therefore, who possesses good gain, is not in any respect more enriched than he who possesses bad gain:

230c

for we have granted that neither of these appears to be more gain than the other.

230d

Hipparchus: True.

230d

Socrates: For neither the more nor the less is present to either of these.

230d

Hipparchus: It is not.

230d

Socrates: But how can any one do, or suffer, more or less with respect to a thing to which neither of these pertains?

230d

Hipparchus: It is impossible.

230d

Socrates: Since, therefore, both are similarly gain and lucrative, it is requisite that we should still further consider this; on what account you call both of them gain, and what it is that you discover to be in both the same. Just as if you should ask me why I just now called both good and bad food similarly food, I should say, It is because each is a dry aliment of the body. And this you will also grant. Or will you not?

230d

Hipparchus: Yes.

230d

Socrates: And there will

230e

be the same mode of answering respecting drink, that we give this appellation to the moist aliment of the body, whether it is good or bad: and the reply in other things will be similar. Do you, therefore, endeavour to imitate me, by answering as follows. You say with respect to good and bad gain, that each of them is gain.

231a

What same thing is it then which, perceiving in these, you denominate gain? But if you are not able to answer me this question, attend to what I am now going to say. Do you then call every possession which any one obtains gain, when he either spends nothing, or receives more than he spends?

231b

Hipparchus: It appears to me that this should be called gain.

231b

Socrates: Do you, therefore, thus denominate such things as follow: If any one at a feast should spend nothing, but when satiated should

become diseased?

231b

Hipparchus: Not I, by Jupiter.

231b

Socrates: But if he should obtain health from feasting, would he acquire gain, or suffer a loss?

231b

Hipparchus: He would acquire gain.

231b

Socrates: This, therefore, is not gain, to acquire any kind of possession whatever.

231b

Hipparchus: It is not.

231b

Socrates: Does it therefore follow that gain is not to be acquired from every kind of possession, whether it be good or bad?

231b

Hipparchus: It appears so.

231b

Socrates: And does it likewise follow that loss will not be sustained from every thing, whether it be good or bad?

231b

Hipparchus: To me it appears so.

231b

Socrates: Do you, therefore, perceive how you again revolve to the same thing? For gain appears to be good, but loss evil.

231b

Hipparchus: I am dubious what to say.

231b

Socrates: And this not unjustly. But still further, answer me this: If any one obtains more than he spends, do you say that this is gain?

231b

Hipparchus: I do, if his gain is not base, but he receives more than he spends, either of gold or silver.

231c

Socrates: And I shall also ask you this: If any one, spending half a pound of gold, should receive double this weight of silver, would he be a gainer, or a loser?

231d

Hipparchus: A loser, certainly, Socrates: for he would only receive half the value of what he spent.

231d

Socrates: But yet he would receive more. Or is not double more than half?

231d

Hipparchus: But silver is not of the same value as gold.

231d

Socrates: It is requisite therefore, as it seems, to add value to gain: for in this case, though the silver is more than the gold, yet you say it is not of equal value.

231d

Hipparchus: And very much so: for thus it is.

231e

Socrates: Value, therefore, is lucrative, whether it is small or great: but that which is without value is without gain.

231e

Hipparchus: It is.

231e

Socrates: Do you say that value is any other value than that which deserves to be acquired?

231e

Hipparchus: I do not.

231e

Socrates: But what do you call that which deserves to be acquired?
The useless, or the useful.

231e

Hipparchus: The useful, certainly.

232a

Socrates: The useful, therefore, is good.

232a

Hipparchus: Yes.

232a

Socrates: Hence, O most virile of all men, have we not a third or a fourth time granted that the lucrative is good?

232a

Hipparchus: So it seems.

232a

Socrates: Do you remember, therefore, whence this discourse of ours originated?

232a

Hipparchus: I think I do.

232a

Socrates: If you do not, I will remind you. It originated from your denying that good men would be willing to acquire every kind of gain, but that they would wish to possess good, and not base gain.

232a

Hipparchus: It did originate from this.

232b

Socrates: But did not our discourse compel us to acknowledge, that all kinds of gain, both small and great, are good?

232b

Hipparchus: It did compel; Socrates, rather than persuade me.

232b

Socrates: But perhaps, after this, it will also persuade you. Now, however, whether you are persuaded, or in whatever manner you may

be affected, do you agree with us, that all gain is good, both small and great?

232b

Hipparchus: I do.

232b

Socrates: And do you agree with me, or not, that all good men aspire after all things that are good?

232b

Hipparchus: I do.

232b

Socrates: But you said that bad men love gain of every kind, both small and great.

232b

Hipparchus: I did say so.

232b

Socrates: According to your assertion, therefore, all men will be lovers of gain, both good and bad men.

232b

Hipparchus: It appears so.

232b

Socrates: No one, therefore, who blames the love of gain will blame rightly, since he who does so is himself also a lover of gain.